

AI Ethics

Course Num: SEIS 651-01 and 02

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Week 3

The background image shows a misty mountain landscape. In the foreground and middle ground, there are dense evergreen forests covering steep slopes. Mist or low clouds are visible between the forested ridges and in the valleys. A semi-transparent dark blue horizontal banner is positioned across the middle of the image, serving as a background for the title text.

Foundations of Ethics

Agenda

Focus Area: Foundations of Ethics

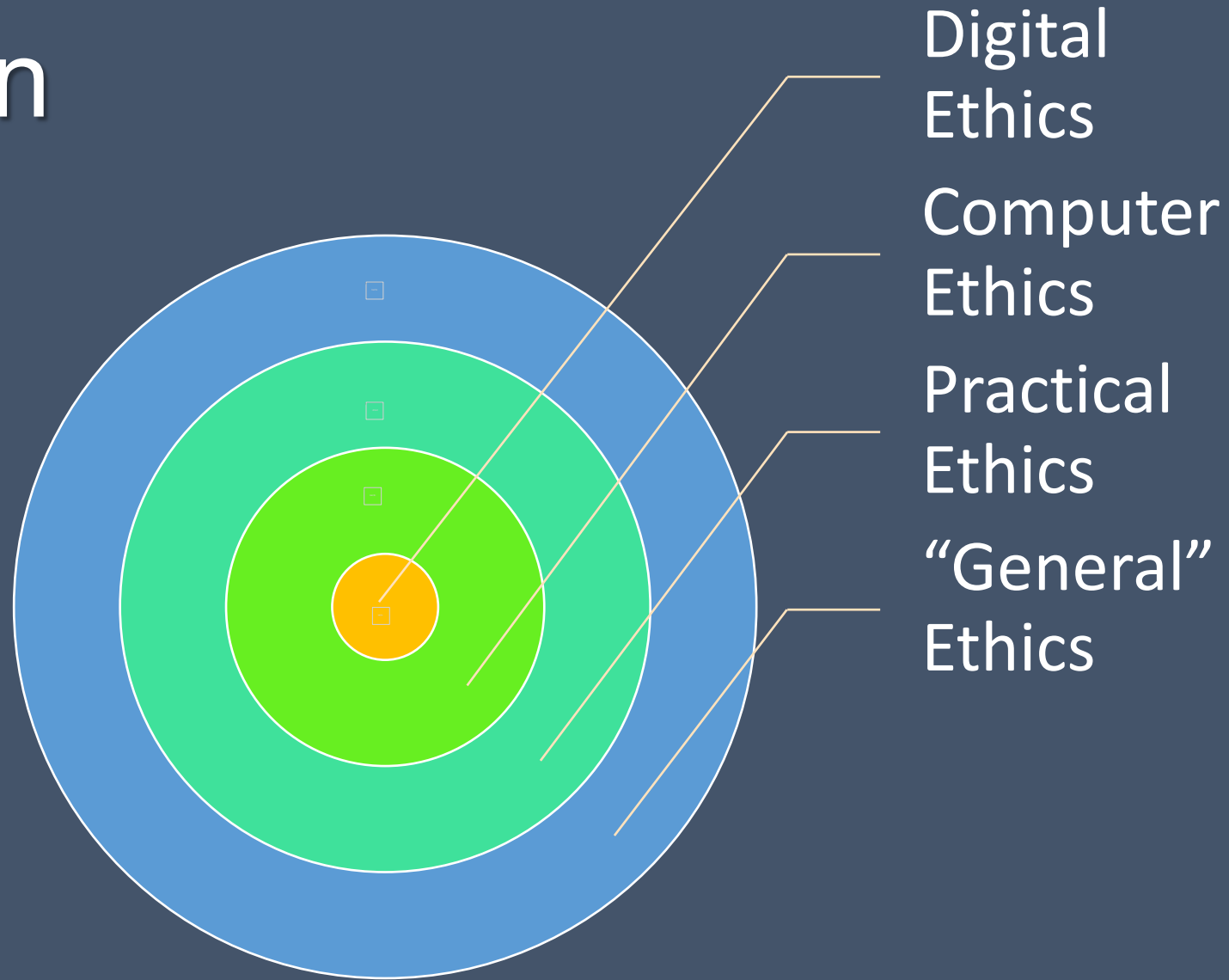
Essential Questions:

- What does it mean to be ethical?
- Can an individual's ethical construct vary from another person's?

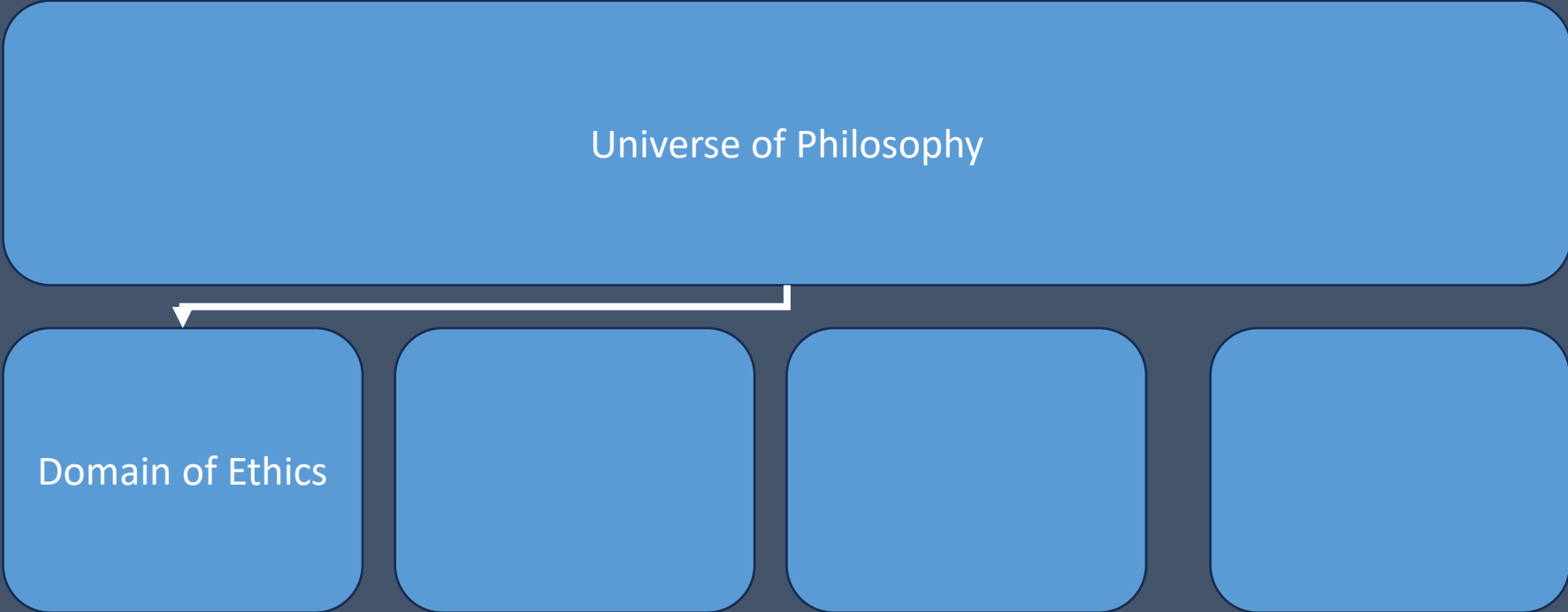
Important Note

We are not rehashing the intricacies of philosophy, psychology or other social sciences. Our purpose is to **build a contextual basis** by which to create an AI ethical paradigm amongst ourselves.

Zeroing In



“General” Ethics



“General” Ethics

Socrates $\Rightarrow$ Plato $\Rightarrow$ Aristotle

“General” Ethics

Aristotle’s focus was on Eudaimonia (yoo-dai-moh-nee-uh)

“Eudemian ethics, notably, consisted of significant ways to build up a prosperous life, which is blissful, successful, as well as good fortunate. Hence, it is likely that eudaimonia indicates many ethical substances of human life towards the best or ultimate satisfaction.”

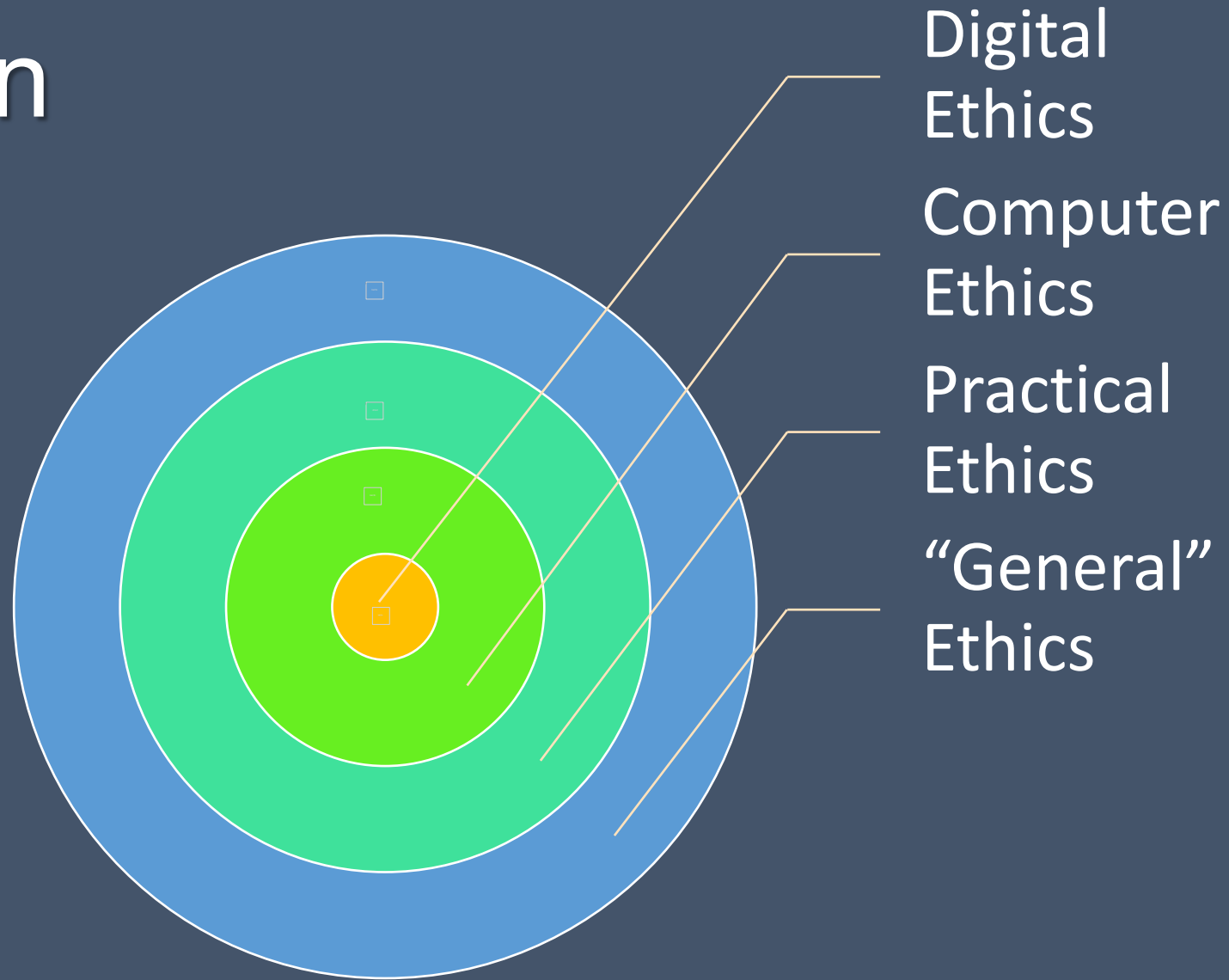
(Thero et. Al., 2022)

“General” Ethics

- Aristotle’s focus was on Eudaimonia
 - Three rudimentary necessities for the happiest life of mankind:
 - Money***
 - Pleasures
 - Being well thought

(Thero et. Al., 2022)

Zeroing In



Practical Ethics

Practical Ethics

John Dewey, 1908

- Developed pragmatic and naturalistic approach to moral philosophy (Simpson, 2018)
- Shifted focus of ethics from metaphysics to social science.
- Distinguishes between MORALS and ETHICS
 - Ethics is the process of inquiry reflective and reasoned evaluation of human conduct.
 - Morals are customary norms and habits that are inherited standards within a society. (Source: Simpson, 2018)

Practical Ethics

“The place for an accurate definition of a subject is at the end of an inquiry rather than at the beginning.”

Dewey (1908)

Practical Ethics

“Ethics is the science that deals with conduct...right or wrong...good or bad...”

Dewey (1908)

Practical Ethics

“Ethics aims to give a systemic account of our judgements about conduct, in so far as these estimate it from the standpoint of right or wrong, good or bad.”

Dewey (1908)
16

Practical Ethics

“To study choice and purpose is psychology; to study choice as affected by the rights of others and to judge it as right or wrong by this standard is ethics.”

Dewey (1908)
17

Practical Ethics

Dietrich Bonhoeffer (1949)

- Bonhoeffer's ethics focus on how to combat evil directly.
- His unfinished work *Ethics* presents a **radically incarnational ethic**, where moral decisions are grounded in the reality of Christ, not in universal principles or metaphysical abstractions (Source: Volume 6: Ethics - International Bonhoeffer Society, English Language Section)
- Influenced situational ethics

Practical Ethics

“Seldom has a generation been as uninterested as ours in any kind of ethical theory or program. The academic question about an ethical system seems to be the most superfluous of all questions. This does not come from any ethical indifference in our times, but rather the reverse, from the pressure of a reality filled with concrete, ethical problems such as we have never had before in the history of the West.”

Bonhoeffer (1949*)

Practical Ethics

“It is worse to be evil than to do evil. It is worse when a liar tells the truth than when a lover of the truth lies, worse when a person who hates humanity practices neighborly love than when a loving person once falls victim to hatred.”

Bonhoeffer (1949*)

Practical Ethics

“With forced tolerance, evil is reinterpreted as good, meanness is overlooked, and the reprehensible is excused. For various reasons, one shies away from a clear No, and finally agrees to everything.”

Bonhoeffer (1949*)

Practical Ethics

“Ethical and intellectual capacity for judgement grow dull before sheen of success and before the desire somehow to share in it.”

Bonhoeffer (1949*)

Practical Ethics

Hannah Arendt (1963)

- Greater focus on political influence on morality.
- Arendt's most famous ethical concept, developed in *Eichmann in Jerusalem*, is the “banality of evil”—the idea that great atrocities can be committed by ordinary individuals who fail to think critically about their actions
- Unlike Kant or Aristotle, Arendt did not build a metaphysical system of ethics. Instead, she focused on real-world moral dilemmas, especially those arising under totalitarian regimes. Her ethics are situational, existential, and deeply political, making them especially relevant in times of crisis. (Source: Macready, 2020)

Practical Ethics

“Ever since the Mayflower Compact was drafted and signed under a different kind of emergency, voluntary associations have been the specifically American remedy for the failure of institutions, the unreliability of men, and the uncertain nature of the future [T]his republic, despite the great turmoil of change and of failure through which it is going at present, may still be in possession of its traditional instruments for facing the future with some measure of confidence.”

Arendt (1963)

Practical Ethics

“that governments pursue policies and employ their power to achieve prescribed goals. But the power structure itself precedes and outlasts all aims, so that power, far from being the means to an end, is actually the very condition enabling a group of people to think and act in terms of the means-ends category. . . . And since government is essentially organized and institutionalized power, the current question What is the end of government? does not make much sense.”

Arendt (1968)

Practical Ethics

Carissa Veliz (2021)

- The generational terms of “AI ethics” and “data ethics” represent the future and past contextual realities, not the present
- “Much of the ethical problems arise from technologies that are not AI. Sometimes it’s a badly designed spreadsheet that causes the problem, or intrusive data collection.”
- “‘data ethics’ emphasizes a vital element of the digital technological toolbox, but only one element. The problem of the future of work, for instance, does not obviously fit under the umbrella of data ethics.”

(Veliz et. al, 2021)

Practical Ethics

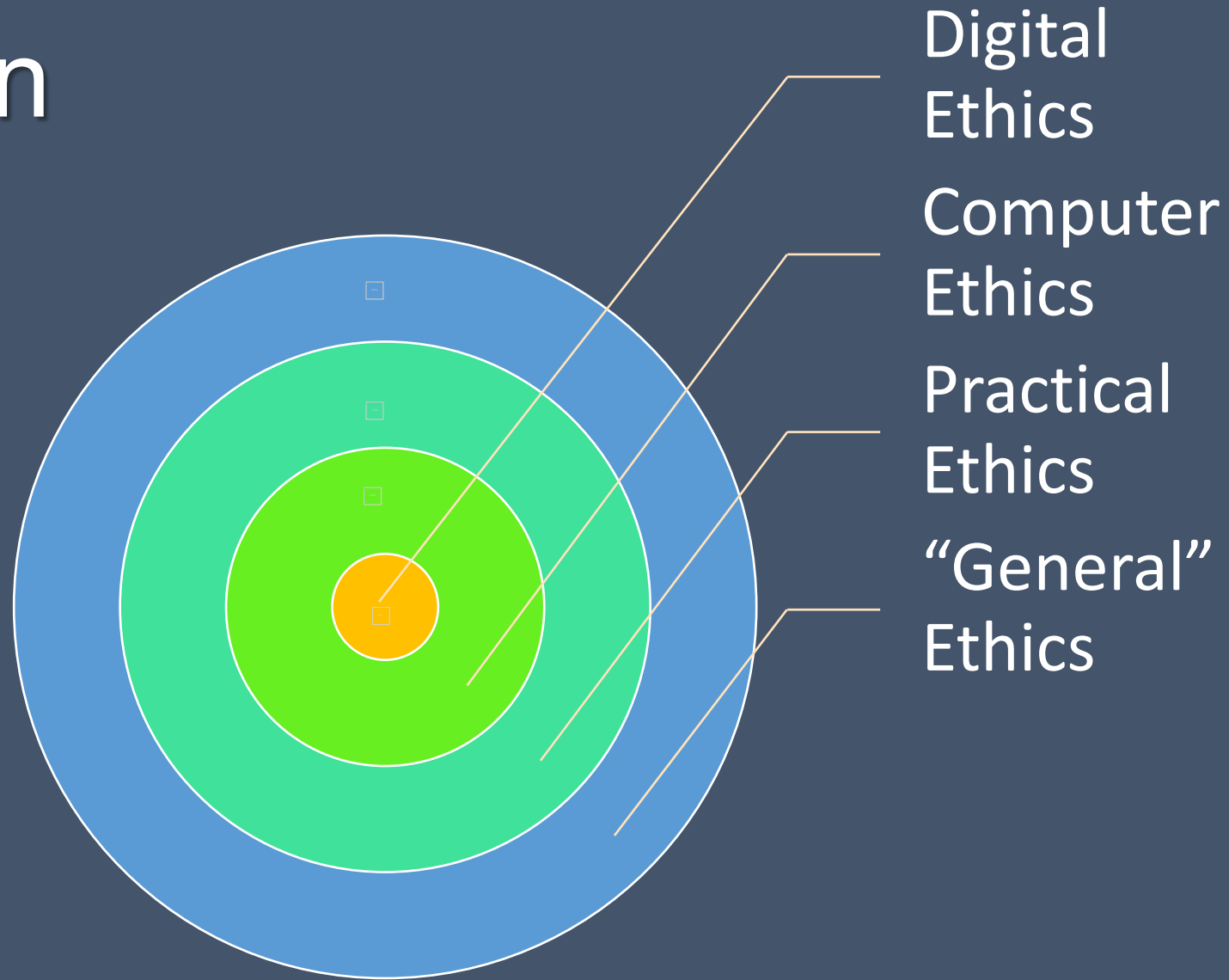
Practical ethics is the reflection and suggested solutions to moral dilemmas that people face in everyday life.

Medical ethics progress made a critical role in making practical ethics a subdiscipline of the philosophical discipline of ethics because medical ethics introduced continuous:

- Scandals and
- New technology

(Veliz et. al, 2021)

Zeroing In



Computer Ethics



Not quite a line-up

Write down on a piece of paper—What is the first name you think of when you see this device?



Not quite a line-up

Write down on a piece of paper—What is the first name you think of when you see this device?

Computer Ethics

Device based focus.

Evolving from Computer Ethics to Digital Ethics 2005-2007

<https://youtu.be/3xIVCRoNCXg?si=yZk3jpa-fDiFC9nI>

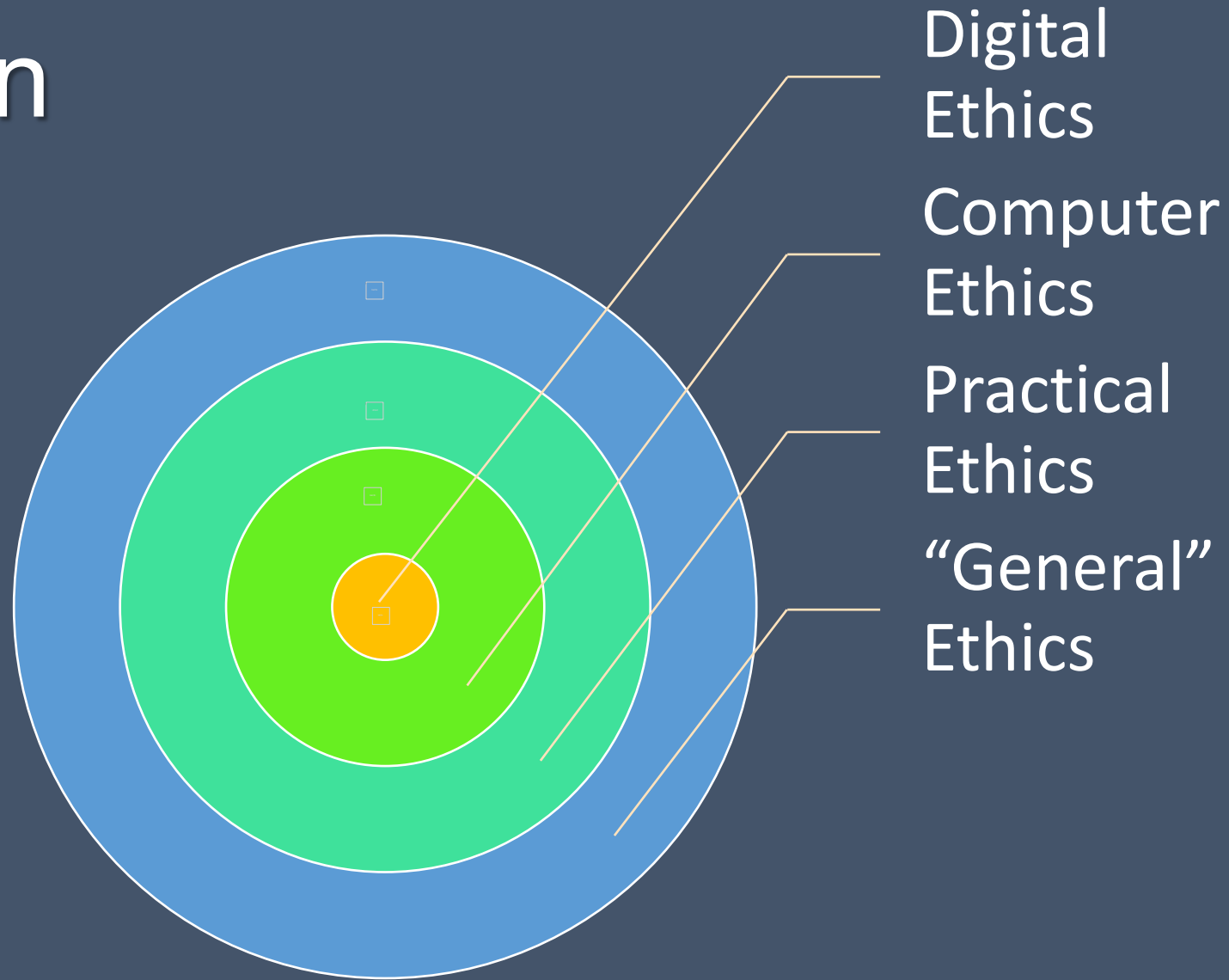


Computer Ethics

The foundation of Digital Ethics is in the field of computer ethics Digital ethics is a cousin rather than a direct descendant of computer ethics

“Computer ethics puts emphasis on machines, but the machines are increasingly becoming invisible to us.” (Veliz et. al, 2021)

Zeroing In



Digital Ethics

Digital Ethics

“The term ‘digital ethics’ aims to encompass AI ethics, data ethics, and other more specific areas of research like robot ethics. It refers to the study within practical ethics of the issues that arise in the design, implementation, and interaction with digital technologies. ‘Digital’ includes whatever has been translated into ones and zeros (the building blocks of code); it involves or is related to the use of computing and stands in opposition to the world of the analogue.

(Veliz et. al, 2021)

Digital Ethics

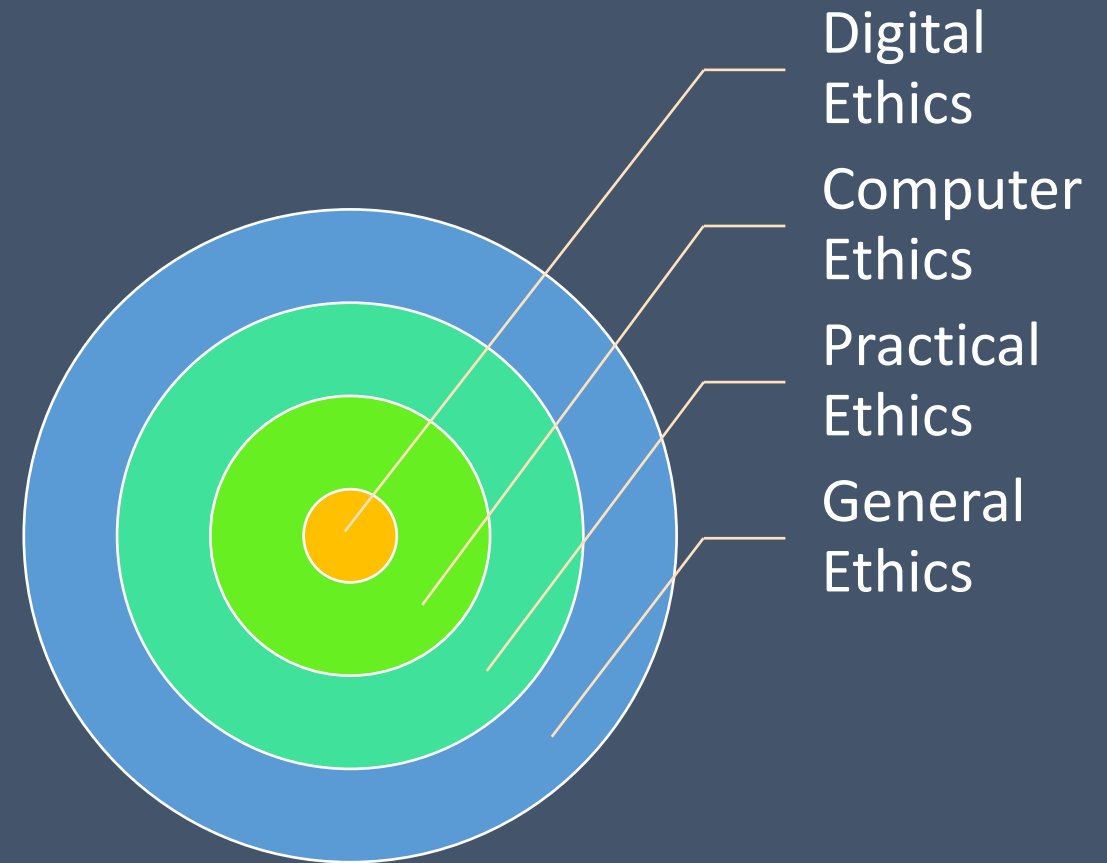
Although 'digital' makes indirect reference to data (binary digits represent data), it goes well beyond it and reminds us of the contrast with the analogue, and how those differences have ethical implications. Social media posts, for instance, are able to spread so rapidly by virtue of their being digital. If we had to copy each message by hand, as we used to with analogue technology, fake news and public shaming would be less of a problem."

(Veliz et. al, 2021)

Reflection

Using the key points from tonight's lesson, examine the following questions:

- 1) What did you already know?
- 2) What is something that was new to you?
- 3) What questions do you have based on what you already knew or now know?



References

- In *Ethics*, Dewey, John; Tufts, James H, 1-14, Chapter xiii, 618 Pages. NY, US: Henry Holt and Company, 1908. DOI:10.1037/13641-001
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- Véliz, Carissa (ed.), *Oxford Handbook of Digital Ethics*, Oxford Handbooks (2023; online edn, Oxford Academic, 10 Nov. 2021), <https://doi-org.ezproxy.stthomas.edu/10.1093/oxfordhb/9780198857815.001.0001>, accessed 6 Sept. 2024.

Lab

The Belmont Report...Anyone?



THE BELMONT REPORT

med chem: pharma business



Lab

What are these videos foreshadowing. If you were doing a documentary on the relationship between the Belmont Report and AI Ethical Practices, what would you focus on and how would renaming AI as Super Intelligence violate the Belmont Standard?